that whereas phishers have to get their prey one by one, pharmers can get a whole bunch of individuals at a time.

6.3.3 How Pharming Works

On a very basic level, a pharmer can work through a Trojan horse. Once a "relevant" Trojan is installed on the host computer, it rewrites the local host files on the computer. What a host file does is convert a URL into a numerical string that your browser understands and takes you to the Web site. However, a compromised host file can direct you to a malicious Web site even if you type in the right URL.

The more enterprising pharmers use a technique called DNS poisoning. DNS translates all Web addresses to numerical strings. It's sort of the telephone directory of the Internet. Now if the DNS directory is "poisoned" or altered in any way, all the users who key in the URL for a particular Web site will be herded off to a bogus site. This is a much scarier scenario. Just imagine if your online banking site were to be poisoned: everyone who would access any information on the site to make any for of transaction would be "sharing" his information with a pharmer.

6.3.4 Stopping Pharmers

Pharming is the work of hackers of some calibre. It is a pretty difficult thing to do, and that's why it's a pretty difficult thing to detect. Pharming requires the knowledge of how to manipulate DNS caches, or gain access to someone's computer files or corporate servers to change settings. Stopping pharming is not an easy task. However, there are some ways one can guard oneself against pharming.

❍ As always, keep your anti-virus and anti-spyware scanners up-to-date.

❍ Check whether the site you are sending confidential information is on a secure connection, i.e. check whether the URL is an HTTPS rather than a HTTP.